

## **Introduction**

This case study will discuss a child named Alex and his associated difficulties in literacy that affect his learning at school. Reasonable adjustments must be made to support Alex's learning in the classroom, via classroom resources, classroom layout, programs, altering modalities, differentiation and promoting awareness of dyslexia (DSE 2005).

## **Definition**

Dyslexia is a learning difference that impedes the skills which are required to be able to read and spell fluently and affects student's schoolwork (Rose, 2009; Chin 2010; Sandman-Hurley, 2017; Frith, 1999; Dyslexia Connect, 2015).

## **Diagnosis**

Rose (2009); Reid (2016); Messurier (2012) advocate that early identification of dyslexia is important as then the sooner the individual can be placed on the correct path in their learning. A diagnosis has not been made for Alex however there are many indicators that are present that suggest a diagnosis of dyslexia. Exemplars (2005); Messurier (2012); Embracing Dyslexia (2013); Seeman (n.d); Redford (2016) advise that many individuals feel inadequate before they have been diagnosed with dyslexia and affects them emotionally too.

- Name of child: Alex
- Sex: Male
- Age : 11
- Problems experienced: speech
- Current indicators: struggling with reading, handwriting and writing.

- Affecting: self-esteem, behaviour, decoding test results poor.

### **Reported Learning difficulties**

Rose (2009) refers to dyslexia as being a difficulty in language learning this is the area that Alex is experiencing difficulties in. Rose (2009); Chin (2010); Frith (1999) discusses there being struggles in phonological awareness, verbal memory and verbal processing speed. This could be linked to Alex's case as he has had problems with his speech, he finds decoding difficult and he dislikes reading. A phonological deficit is the main reason that those with dyslexia experience difficulties with reading as they cannot link sounds to the letters (Rose, 2009; Firth, 2003; Frith, 2014; 1999; Chin, 2010; Baxter, 2010). Forbes (2016) suggests that those with dyslexia have a barrier with writing. Alex could also suffer from dysgraphia due to his difficulties writing as it appears 'wobbly' (Dyslexia, 2016; Kaplan, Dewey, Crawford, & Wilson, 2001).

### **Other difficulties**

Chin (2010); Exemplars (2005) advise that many individuals with dyslexia have poor organisation skills, process information slowly, find sequencing information difficult, they often seem more able as individuals than what they produce in their written work, and lethargic after a school day. Chin (2010); Rose (2009); Baxter (2010); Sandman-Hurley (2017) advise that many Individuals with dyslexia have poor memory which can therefore hinder their learning therefore must be checked for Alex.

### **Strengths**

Alex enjoys making model airplanes, maths, and puzzles and has excellent problem solving and reasoning skills. It is important that those individuals with dyslexia such as Alex should have their strengths focused and built upon to achieve success (Dua, 2017; Dyslexia Mountains, 2014; Dyslexia International, 2013; Smart, 2009; Reid, 2016; Sandman-Hurley, 2017; Messurier, 2012; Carmichael, 2016; Scope, 2017; Dyslexia Buddy Network, 2015; Foss, 2014; Made by dyslexia, 2017). Many individuals have an artistic creative nature or have a specific interest and strength (Smart, 2009; Dyslexia International, 2013; Dyslexia Mountains, 2014).

### **Recommended action:**

Alex's enjoys puzzles therefore his teacher could use this information and make a spelling literacy game in which Alex has to piece the parts together. This would aid him with his writing which is where his weakness lays. Classroom resources and layout have to be adapted and ensure that they are multi-sensory so that the children can touch objects during their learning and this can be applied to Alex with his literacy lessons (Exemplars, 2005; Teach Find, 2011; Action Dyslexia, 2012; Cochrane, Gregory & Saunders, 2012; Department for Education, 2012 ; National Improvement Hub, 2017).

### **Testing- Other professionals**

Occupational Therapy For Children (2019) refers to testing and "Anyone who is suspected to have dyslexia should have a comprehensive evaluation, including medical, psychological, behavioural, hearing, vision, and intelligence testing. " There can be an existence of more than one condition in an individual that must be considered in Alex's case (Rose, 2009; Kaplan et al. , 2001; Reid, 2016). Alex would require a test for audio and sight tests to ensure that there are no other disorders present (Dyslexia.com, 2015; Occupational Therapy for Children, 2019). An occupational therapist and speech therapist could also observe him in the classroom and

make any recommendations that would support Alex (Occupational Therapy for Children, 2019).

### **Assessment**

Firstly, Alex must have some assessments to determine his weaknesses that need to be addressed by observing his behaviour before an intervention is introduced (Reid, 2016; United Nations, 2014). There is a method of identifying dyslexia in children who have literacy difficulties by observing their responses compared to their other peers, as screening can be unreliable (Rose, 2009; Exemplars, 2005; Reid, 2016; Frith, 1999; Firth, 2012). This should be conducted in the Alex's classroom and his test results analysed and obtained from numerous sources (Reid, 2016). Reid (2016) refers to a tests for phonological processing and dyslexia screening that takes into account those in Alex's age which can be implemented as he has issues with decoding text.

### **Intervention Plan**

It is important that an intervention plan for Alex is implemented once discussed with his teachers and parents (Redford, 2016; United Nations, 2014). Observing how the child responds to an intervention that is set in place and then reacting to this knowledge is necessary (Rose, 2009 ; Reid, 2016; Exemplars, 2005; Hodge, 2000; Dyslexia Australia, 2010 ; Sandman-Hurley, 2017; Forbes, 2016). These individuals struggle to access the curriculum therefore it is vital interventions eradicate these barriers (Redford 2016).

### **Reading and Spelling Intervention plan**

There are many different programs and approaches that a school can choose from (Reid, 2016; Brooks, 2016; Rose, 2009). It is important to build upon a child's resilience, this is to ensure that the child is aware that dyslexia is not just as difficulty but a different way of learning therefore a plan is needed for Alex is vital to build his resilience and boost his self-esteem (Palti, 1998; Exemplars, 2005). It is important in Alex's case that an intervention program for him is implemented immediately (Rose, 2009; Reid, 2016; Exemplars, 2005; Hodge, 2000; Dyslexia Australia, 2010; Sandman-Hurley, 2017). Alex's school need to choose a program that is the most appropriate for his needs and age such as a computer based program for children with dyslexia called 'Units of Sound' (Brooks 2016). Phonics knowledge should be addressed as it is a weakness within the brain of those with dyslexia and Alex would use these skills in his reading (Rose, 2009; Firth, 2003; Frith, 2014,1999; Chin, 2010; Baxter, 2010; Dyslexia Australia, 2010; Hodge, 2000; Reid, 2016). To address Alex's difficulties with reading and spelling the school could introduce a phonics programme such as Read, Write, Inc. (Oxford University Press, 2019; Brooks, 2016; Dyslexiamom, 2011; Dyslexia Australia, 2010; Reid, 2016). RWI is a structured programme and can be implemented for those in year 5 and 6 of Alex's age if they are having difficulties with their literacy skills. This is a multisensory approach to help Alex with his difficulties in his phonological awareness as he finds it difficult to decode words whilst reading and this in turn will help his spelling and writing too (Dyslexics.org 2019). Short term objectives would be to learn all of the prescribed digraphs and long term for Alex to read fluently .Another programme that is recommended for Alex's school is 'Reading Recovery' which helps to develop reading through thirty minutes a day (Brooks 2016).

**Time Scale:**

Alex could have the RWI sessions over a ten week term initially (Oxford University Press, 2019; Brooks, 2016; Dyslexiamom, 2011; Dyslexia Australia, 2010; Reid, 2016). Alex would be in small groups of other children that are of a similar level. The RWI plan would be five sessions every day for an hour with reading the RWI books. This programme is not only an intervention but can be a whole class approach and continue throughout the school for all individuals. The teacher illustrates cards with pictures with a matching digraph in a multi-sensory approach. It involves segmenting and blending sounds together and using “nonsense” words. The scheme is very prescriptive and the teacher is provided with a handbook of lesson plans (Brooks 2016).

### **Baseline**

To create a baseline for Alex’s reading abilities he could take an initial RWI assessment at the beginning of the ten week term and then the same test at the end of ten weeks to determine if progression has been made. A test in guided reading could be checked for decoding and comprehension of a specific level book and a more difficult level using reading record levelled books and tests (Oxford University Press, 2019; Brooks, 2016). Brooks (2016); Exemplars (2005) refers to successful gains after assessing data when examining progress were achieved after RWI and such intervention programs.

### **Self-esteem issues- raise confidence**

Many children with dyslexia have issues with their self-esteem and compare themselves to their friends (Exemplars, 2005; Dua, 2017; Reid, 2016; Rose, 2009; Chin, 2010; CPD College, 2016). Alex compares himself to his peers in a negative light which therefore affects his self-esteem and this must be addressed by his school. Young people such as Alex feel humiliated reading aloud (Rose, 2009; Reid, 2016 ; Smart, 2009). This can be linked to Alex’s case as his

behaviour deteriorates as he is attempting to avoid reading and writing therefore this must be tackled to ensure he is more engaged (Exemplars, 2005 ; Alexander-Passe, 2006). Individuals with dyslexia feel emotional stress and anxiety (Reid, 2016; Messurier, 2012; Alexander-Passe, 2006; 2010; Redford, 2016).

To combat the self-esteem concerns Alex's school need to raise and positively promote the awareness within the school and community about dyslexia and to give him a sense of himself (Exemplars ,2005; Frith ,1999; Scope, 2017; Humphrey, 2003; Rose, 2009). In McAyla's school they had created a successful supportive school environment reduce stigma using modes such as creating newsletters by informing and advising the community about dyslexia therefore Alex's school must implement this method (Dyslexia Connect, 2015; Humphrey, 2003; Exemplars, 2005). It is important therefore that dyslexia awareness is promoted to allow children to understand that it is a different learning style not a disability and children with dyslexia should not be seen as different to prevent bullying and isolation (Humphrey, 2003 ; Rose, 2009; Exemplars, 2005; Frith, 1999; Dyslexic Advantage, 2013).

## **Summary**

### **Dyslexic friendly schools**

Under the Disability Discrimination Act 1992 and Disability Standards for Education 2005 teachers have a responsibility to ensure that those with disabilities are not discriminated against. This offers children such as Alex an inclusive approach and provide for example different equipment or adapting the environment to support their needs. Alex's school would provide Information to The National Consistent Collection of Data to demonstrate that they have included Alex and made reasonable adjustments. Action Dyslexia (2012) ; Cochrane et

al., (2012); Department for Education (2012) refers to how schools are classed as Dyslexia friendly when they have made adjustments for students which Alex's school can aim to do .

### **Recommendations for Alex's school**

- Alex's school must also ensure that there is training about dyslexia for staff members this way Alex has an experienced class teacher (Exemplars, 2005; Forbes. 2016; 2017; Jenkinson, 2006; Made by dyslexia, 2017).
- It is important that Alex's school has a solid communication link between his school and his parents and they work together with their perspective too ( Exemplars, 2005; Forbes, 2016; Griffiths, 2014; Reid, 2016 ; EdChat, 2003; Dyslexia Australia, 2010; Rose, 2009). Alex's parents need to be brought into school to discuss proposed interventions. Support from everyone around an individual with dyslexia is important (Messurier, 2012; Reid, 2016).
- **Different modalities-** Exemplars (2005) Alex can be given additional time to finish his assessments and examinations as in the case of McAyla. Alex can sit a verbal assessment as he has difficulties writing. Another adjustment for Alex could be the mode of which homework is submitted could be altered such as submission of a PowerPoint (Exemplars, 2005).
- Alex's school must ensure teaching is of a high standard and inclusion. Armstrong and Squires (2015); Reid (2016); Brooks (2016) state individuals with dyslexia need "good quality teaching." Reid (2016); Florian (2010) refers to inclusion and how there are varying ways of including a child in the classroom environment. **Teaching strategies-** In addition to an intervention plan it is recommended that Alex's school ensures that his teacher adopts different teaching strategies in the classroom and provides resources

to address those individuals with dyslexia using different methods to support their weaknesses. A teacher can introduce tactile objects and tinted colour glasses and methods such as different coloured writing on the board, spelling practice, memory games, using multisensory methods and building up on phonetic knowledge (Exemplars, 2005; Hodge, 2000; Department of Education, 2012). It is important to adapt and find ways to suit their learning styles and using differentiation (Reid, 2016; Rose, 2009; Messurier, 2012).

In conclusion, those with dyslexia need to receive intervention to ensure that they can access the learning (DSE 2005).

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